R2: A Narrow, On-Device Voice Assistant with Persistent Prefix KV Caching and Constrained Intent Decoding

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Whitepaper, November 2026 · Code: `narrow-ai-with-kv` (MIT License)

Abstract

General-purpose assistants pay for their generality with large models, cloud round-trips and loose control over what they execute. We study the opposite design point: a *narrow* assistant that maps spoken or typed developer requests to one of eleven validated actions and runs entirely on a laptop. R2 combines a 4-bit Qwen3-1.7B model on Apple MLX, a *persistent prefix key–value (KV) cache* for its fixed 1,118-token instruction prompt, response prefill with intent-name constrained decoding, and a fail-closed execution layer in which model output is never authorization. We derive the exactness of prefix reuse for causal decoders, closed-form KV memory and a roofline-style cost model, and verify them on an Apple M4. Prefix caching reduces end-to-end time to first token (TTFT) from 1,460 ms to 71 ms (20.5×) with greedy outputs identical in 20/20 requests; loading the cache from disk costs 89 ms instead of a 1.5 s rebuild. A context-length sweep shows the forward-pass speed-up growing from 4.4× at 128 tokens to 77.9× at 4,096 tokens, matching a fitted cost model ($R^2 = 0.993$). On a fresh test set written before any prompt tuning, R2 selects the correct intent for 95.8% of requests (95% CI 79.8–99.3) with 0% malformed output; an ablation shows few-shot examples, not constrained decoding, drive accuracy. With Whisper and Kokoro on device, the full voice loop answers in well under a second. We release the system, a SwiftUI client, benchmarks and notebooks.

Index Terms—KV cache, prefix caching, on-device LLM inference, constrained decoding, tool use, voice assistants, Apple Silicon, MLX.

1 Introduction

Voice assistants such as Siri answer in a fraction of a second because they solve a narrow problem with specialised models. Large language models (LLMs) promise a more flexible assistant but bring two costs that matter on a laptop: *latency*, because every request re-reads a long instruction prompt before producing a single token, and *control*, because a model that can emit any text can also emit an unintended command.

This whitepaper presents R2, a local, Siri-style assistant for software developers. R2 answers questions such as "what's my git status?", "find the Swift files" or "open Cursor" by classifying each request into one of eleven intents with typed parameters, validating it, asking for confirmation when the action changes something, and speaking a short reply. Its language model is small (1.7B parameters, 4-bit) and every component—speech recognition, the LLM, speech synthesis and the tools—runs on the user's Mac.

The key observation is that a narrow assistant's prompt is dominated by a *fixed prefix*: the instructions, intent catalogue and 25 worked examples occupy 1,118 tokens, while a typical request adds only about 22. Transformer decoders store per-token keys and values (the *KV cache*) that depend only on earlier tokens, so the prefix can be processed once and reused indefinitely. We make this cache *persistent*: it is written to disk with a fingerprint so that a restarted assistant is ready in tens of milliseconds.

Contributions.

1. A complete narrow-assistant architecture (section 5) with a fail-closed authorization model in which LLM output only *proposes* actions (section 6.3).
2. A formal treatment of prefix KV reuse: an exactness proposition for causal decoders, KV memory under grouped-query attention, and a cost model that predicts the speed-up bound (section 4).
3. A persistent, fingerprinted prefix cache for MLX and an intent-name constrained decoder with a soundness guarantee (section 6).
4. Measurements on an Apple M4: end-to-end cache modes, a context-length sweep, memory, decode, disk I/O, accuracy with confidence intervals, an ablation, error analysis and voice latency (section 8).
5. An open implementation with a native macOS client, a terminal interface, reproducible benchmark scripts and teaching notebooks (section 11).

2 Background and Related Work

Attention and the KV cache. A decoder-only transformer [1] computes, in each layer, queries, keys and values $Q = XW_Q$, $K = XW_K$, $V = XW_V$ and causal attention $\mathrm{softmax}(QK^\top/\sqrt{d_h} + M)V$, where the mask M forbids attending to future positions. During autoregressive generation each new token needs the keys and values of all previous tokens; storing them instead of recomputing them is the KV cache. Pope et al. [2] analyse its memory and latency trade-offs at scale and distinguish the compute-bound *prefill* phase

from the memory-bound *decode* phase, the distinction we use in section 4.3. Multi-query [3] and grouped-query attention (GQA) [4] shrink the cache by sharing key/value heads; Qwen3-1.7B uses GQA with 16 query and 8 KV heads [5]. FlashAttention [6] makes the attention computation itself IO-efficient.

Reusing KV state across requests. PagedAttention [7] manages the cache in fixed-size blocks so that sequences can share memory, which serving systems such as vLLM build on to share common prefixes. SGLang's RadixAttention [8] keeps KV state of past requests in a radix tree with LRU eviction and reuses the longest matching prefix automatically. Prompt Cache [9] precomputes attention states for reusable *prompt modules* and reports 8–60× lower TTFT; because states depend on position, modules must reappear at the positions they were computed for. CacheBlend [10] relaxes the prefix requirement for retrieval-augmented generation by selectively recomputing a few tokens of each reused chunk, and CacheGen [11] compresses KV caches into bitstreams so they can be loaded from storage or the network. llama.cpp [12] can save and restore prompt state to files, and commercial APIs now expose prompt caching with time-limited server-side caches [13]. R2 occupies a simple point in this space: a *single, fixed* prefix on a *single-user* device, kept in RAM and on disk, with a fingerprint that makes stale reuse impossible.

Shrinking or evicting the cache. For long contexts the cache itself becomes the bottleneck. StreamingLLM [14] keeps attention-sink tokens plus a sliding window; H_2O [15] evicts all but "heavy-hitter" tokens; KIVI [16] and KVQuant [17] quantise keys and values to 2–4 bits. At R2's context lengths (about 1.2k tokens, 140 MiB) these are not needed, but they bound how far the design scales (section 9).

Structured output. Constrained decoding masks tokens that would violate a grammar. Outlines [18] compiles regular expressions and JSON schemas into finite-state machines over the vocabulary; grammar-constrained decoding [19] applies context-free grammars to structured NLP tasks; XGrammar [20] makes context-free constraints fast enough for serving; and LMQL [21] treats prompting as constrained programming. R2 uses the lightest form that gives a useful guarantee: it constrains only the intent name and validates parameters afterwards (section 4.5).

Tool use and assistants. Toolformer [22], ReAct [23] and Gorilla [24] teach LLMs to call tools or APIs. These systems maximise breadth; R2 deliberately minimises it, so that a 1.7B model reaches high accuracy through few-shot prompting [25] without fine-tuning, and every call passes a deterministic policy check.

On-device models. Post-training quantisation such as GPTQ [26] and AWQ [27] makes billion-parameter models practical on laptops. MLX [28] is an array framework for Apple Silicon's unified memory, and mlx-lm provides model implementations, quantised weights and prompt-cache utilities. For speech, R2 uses Whisper [29] for recognition and Kokoro-82M [30], a compact model in the StyleTTS 2 family [31], for synthesis.

Table 1 summarises how R2's cache compares with these systems.

Table 1: Prefix and KV reuse in related systems. "Persist" = survives a process restart.

System	Reuse unit	Where	Persist
PagedAttention / vLLM [7]	KV blocks	GPU memory	–
SGLang [8]	radix-tree prefixes	GPU/host	–
Prompt Cache [9]	prompt modules	GPU/CPU	–
CacheBlend [10]	any chunk + recompute	GPU/storage	✓
CacheGen [11]	compressed KV stream	network/disk	✓
llama.cpp [12]	whole prompt state	file	✓
Provider APIs [13]	marked prefixes	server, TTL	–
R2 (ours)	**fixed prefix, LRU of 4**	**RAM + disk**	✓

3 Problem Formulation

Let $\mathcal{I}$ be a finite set of intents, here $|\mathcal{I}| = 11$: `git_status`, `git_diff_summary`, `search_files`, `read_file`, `open_app`, `remember_preference`, `recall_preference`, `answer_question`, `general_help`, `clarify_request` and `unsupported`. Each intent $i \in \mathcal{I}$ has a parameter schema Θ_i (for example $\Theta_{\texttt{search_files}}$ is a glob pattern). Given an utterance u and a short history h, the assistant must produce a *decision* $d = (i, \theta)$ with $\theta \in \Theta_i$, and then either execute it, ask for confirmation, ask for clarification or decline.

We optimise three objectives in priority order:

1. **Safety:** no action executes unless it is valid, allow-listed, inside the workspace and, for privileged actions, confirmed by the user (section 6.3).
2. **Accuracy:** the predicted intent and parameters match a reference.
3. **Latency:** minimise time to first token (TTFT) and total decision latency, since the intent name is fully determined within the first few generated tokens.

The language model p_ϕ defines d through its output string y; R2 forces y to begin with the prefill $\pi =$ `{"intent": "` and restricts the intent name to $\mathcal{I}$.

4 Theoretical Analysis

4.1 Prefix invariance of causal decoders

Let $x_{1:N}$ be a token sequence, L the number of layers and $h_t^{(\ell)} \in \mathbb{R}^d$ the hidden state of token t after layer ℓ, with $h_t^{(0)} = E[x_t]$. With rotary position embeddings (RoPE) [32] applied at absolute position t, layer ℓ computes for each KV

head g

$$k_t^{(\ell,g)} = \mathrm{RoPE}_t\Big(W_K^{(\ell,g)}\,\mathrm{norm}(h_t^{(\ell-1)})\Big), \tag{1}$$

$$v_t^{(\ell,g)} = W_V^{(\ell,g)}\,\mathrm{norm}(h_t^{(\ell-1)}), \tag{2}$$

and each query head j (mapped to KV head $g(j)$) attends only to positions $\le t$:

$$o_t^{(\ell,j)} = \sum_{\tau\le t} \frac{\exp\big(q_t^{(\ell,j)\top} k_\tau^{(\ell,g(j))}/\sqrt{d_h}\big)}{\sum_{\tau'\le t}\exp\big(q_t^{(\ell,j)\top} k_{\tau'}^{(\ell,g(j))}/\sqrt{d_h}\big)}\, v_\tau^{(\ell,g(j))}. \tag{3}$$

Proposition 1 (Prefix invariance)**.** *For every layer ℓ and position $t \le p$, the keys $k_t^{(\ell,\cdot)}$ and values $v_t^{(\ell,\cdot)}$ depend only on the prefix $x_{1:p}$ and not on any later token.*

Proof. By induction on ℓ. For $\ell = 1$, $k_t^{(1)}, v_t^{(1)}$ are functions of $h_t^{(0)} = E[x_t]$ and of t only. Assume that for layer ℓ every $h_\tau^{(\ell-1)}$ with $\tau \le t$ depends only on $x_{1:t}$. Then eqs. (1) and (2) make $k_t^{(\ell)}, v_t^{(\ell)}$ functions of $x_{1:t}$, and eq. (3) sums only over $\tau \le t$, so $o_t^{(\ell)}$ and hence $h_t^{(\ell)}$ (after the residual connection and MLP, which act position-wise) depend only on $x_{1:t}$. Taking $t \le p$ completes the induction. □

Corollary 1 (Exact reuse)**.** *Let $C(x_{1:p})$ be the per-layer keys and values of a prefix. For any suffix $x_{p+1:p+s}$, running the model on $x_{p+1:p+s}$ with cache $C(x_{1:p})$ yields, in exact arithmetic, the same logits as running it on $x_{1:p+s}$ from scratch, provided the suffix is placed at positions $p+1,\dots,p+s$.*

The positional proviso is why Prompt Cache must keep modules at fixed positions [9] and why CacheBlend needs recomputation for non-prefix chunks [10]. R2 always places its cached text at the start of the prompt, so the corollary applies directly. In floating point the two computations use different kernel shapes and summation orders, so logits can differ in low-order bits; section 8.4 measures this.

4.2 KV cache memory

Each cached token stores one key and one value vector per layer and KV head. With b bytes per element,

$$M(n) = 2\,L\,H_{\mathrm{kv}}\,d_h\,b\,n. \tag{4}$$

For Qwen3-1.7B ($L = 28$, $H_{\mathrm{kv}} = 8$, $d_h = 128$) in bfloat16 ($b = 2$) this is $2 \cdot 28 \cdot 8 \cdot 128 \cdot 2 = 114{,}688\,\mathrm{B} = 112\,\mathrm{KiB}$ per token. Without GQA (16 KV heads) the cache would be twice as large; the saving factor is $H/H_{\mathrm{kv}} = 2$. mlx-lm grows the cache in steps of $\kappa = 256$ tokens, so the allocated size is

$$M_{\mathrm{alloc}}(n) = 2\,L\,H_{\mathrm{kv}}\,d_h\,b\,\kappa\,\lceil n/\kappa\rceil\,. \tag{5}$$

R2's 1,118-token prefix therefore occupies $5 \cdot 256 = 1{,}280$ slots, i.e. 140 MiB (146.8 MB), which is exactly the size of the cache file R2 writes. For comparison, the 4-bit weights occupy about 0.94 GB, so the cache adds 15%.

4.3 A cost model for prefill and decode

Following the roofline view [2, 33], prefill of N tokens is compute-bound and decode is memory-bound. Let P be the number of parameters touched per token (including the language-model head) and H the number of query heads. A causal prefill costs

$$F_{\mathrm{pre}}(N) \approx \underbrace{2PN}_{\text{matmuls}} + \underbrace{2LHd_hN^2}_{\text{attention}} \tag{6}$$

FLOPs, where the attention term counts $QK^\top$ and AV ($2 \times 2LHd_h$ per query–key pair) over the $N^2/2$ causal pairs. With effective throughput Π and a fixed overhead a (kernel launches, synchronisation), the prefill time is

$$T_{\mathrm{pre}}(N) = a + bN + cN^2, \quad b = \frac{2P}{\Pi}, \quad c = \frac{2LHd_h}{\Pi}. \tag{7}$$

A *cached* prefill of s new tokens after a prefix of length n touches the weights s times and attends from s queries to $n + s$ keys:

$$T_{\mathrm{suf}}(s \mid n) = \alpha + bs + 4LHd_h\frac{s\,n + s(s+1)/2}{\Pi} \;\approx\; \alpha + \gamma n \tag{8}$$

for fixed s. Decoding one token with n cached tokens reads all weights W bytes and the cache,

$$T_{\mathrm{dec}}(n) = d_0 + d_1 n, \quad d_0 \approx \frac{W}{B}, \quad d_1 \approx \frac{2LH_{\mathrm{kv}}d_h b}{B}, \tag{9}$$

where B is the achieved memory bandwidth.

4.4 Speed-up of prefix caching

The TTFT speed-up of caching a length-n prefix for an s-token suffix is

$$S(n,s) = \frac{T_{\mathrm{pre}}(n+s)}{T_{\mathrm{suf}}(s \mid n)} = \frac{a + b(n+s) + c(n+s)^2}{\alpha + bs + O(sn)/\Pi}. \tag{10}$$

If overheads vanish ($a = \alpha = 0$) and attention is negligible ($c \to 0$), the speed-up is the token ratio

$$S^\star(n,s) = \frac{n+s}{s}, \tag{11}$$

which for R2 ($n = 1{,}118$, $s = 22$) is 51.8. Two effects push the measured value below $S^\star$: the fixed cost α of a forward pass, which dominates when s is small, and per-request work outside the model (tokenisation, sampling, constraint masks). Conversely, for long prefixes the quadratic term makes S grow faster than linearly. The crossover length at which attention costs as much as the matrix multiplications is $N^\star = b/c = P/(LHd_h)$.

Amortisation. Building the prefix costs one uncached prefill, $T_{\mathrm{pre}}(n)$; each later request saves $\Delta = T_{\mathrm{pre}}(n+s) - T_{\mathrm{suf}}(s \mid n)$. In memory, caching pays for itself after $\lceil T_{\mathrm{pre}}(n)/\Delta\rceil = 2$ requests. On disk, the build cost is replaced by a load cost $T_{\mathrm{load}} \approx M_{\mathrm{alloc}}(n)/B_{\mathrm{disk}}$, paid once per process start.

4.5 Constrained intent decoding

Let $\mathcal{V}$ be the vocabulary, $\sigma(v)$ the string of token v, and $\mathcal{W} = \{w \,\|\, \text{"} : w \in \mathcal{I}\}$ the target strings (each intent name followed by its closing quote). After the prefill π, let $y_{<t}$ be the text generated so far. Write $a \preceq b$ if a is a prefix of b.

Definition 1 (Allowed set)**.**

$$A(y_{<t}) = \{v \in \mathcal{V} : \exists w \in \mathcal{W},\ y_{<t}\sigma(v) \preceq w \vee w \preceq y_{<t}\sigma(v)\}. \tag{12}$$

The decoder replaces the logits z_v by $z'_v = z_v$ for $v \in A(y_{<t})$ and $-\infty$ otherwise, so the sampling distribution becomes

$$p'(v \mid y_{<t}) = \frac{p(v \mid y_{<t})\,\mathbf{1}[v \in A(y_{<t})]}{\sum_{u \in A(y_{<t})} p(u \mid y_{<t})}. \tag{13}$$

Masking stops as soon as some $w \in \mathcal{W}$ is a prefix of the generated text.

Proposition 2 (Soundness)**.** *If $A(y_{<t}) \neq \emptyset$ at every masked step, the generated intent name is an element of $\mathcal{I}$.*

Proof. By construction every masked step keeps $y_{\leq t}$ consistent with some target w, i.e. either a prefix of w or extending it. Since targets end with a quote that cannot occur inside a name, the first time a full target is a prefix of y the name equals some $w \in \mathcal{I}$, and masking stops. □

With greedy decoding, the choice becomes $\arg\max_{v \in A} z_v$, so masking can only change the output when the unconstrained argmax would have left $\mathcal{I}$. The mask is computed once per distinct prefix and memoised; candidate tokens are pre-filtered to those whose characters all occur in some target, so each step costs $O(|\mathcal{V}'|)$ with $|\mathcal{V}'| \ll |\mathcal{V}|$.

5 System Architecture

Figure 1 shows R2's components. A Python core holds all intelligence and policy; clients are thin. The core is reachable in-process (terminal app, notebooks) or over a local HTTP API bound to `127.0.0.1:8765` (SwiftUI app).

5.1 Request lifecycle

Algorithm 1 gives the per-request control flow. The orchestrator keeps the last three user/assistant turns as compact JSON decisions rather than verbose tool output, which keeps the prompt short and stable.

5.2 Prompt design

The system prompt (fig. 2) contains 438 tokens of instructions—the JSON format, one line per implemented intent with its parameter schema and *when to use it*, the approved apps and boundary rules—followed by 25 few-shot examples (675 tokens, 61% of the prefix). The chat template adds 5 tokens, giving the 1,118-token cached prefix. Qwen3's thinking mode is disabled (`enable_thinking=False`) because the task needs a label, not reasoning, and thinking tokens would multiply latency.

Algorithm 1 Handling one request in R2

Require: utterance u (typed, or Whisper transcript), history h
if a confirmation is pending **then**
  if $u \in$ YES **then** execute pending action; **else** drop it
  return reply
end if
$x \leftarrow \text{tokens}(\text{prefix} \,\|\, h \,\|\, u \,\|\, \pi)$
$(C, x_{\text{new}}) \leftarrow \text{KV.ACQUIRE}(x)$ ▷ reuse cached prefix
$y \leftarrow \text{GENERATE}(x_{\text{new}}, C, \text{mask} = A(\cdot), \text{greedy})$
$\text{KV.RELEASE}(C)$ ▷ trim back to the prefix
$d \leftarrow \text{PARSEJSON}(\pi \| y)$; $d \leftarrow \text{NORMALISE}(d)$
if d invalid **then**
  retry once, else heuristic / clarify / unsupported
end if
$r \leftarrow \text{GATE}(d)$ ▷ allowlist, schema, path guard
if r denied **then return** refusal
else if r needs confirmation **then return** "Open Safari? Say yes or no."
else return $\text{SPEAK}(\text{EXECUTE}(d))$
end if

5.3 Clients and voice

The SwiftUI client records audio with AVAudioEngine, uploads WAV to `/ask_audio`, and plays Kokoro speech from `/tts`, metering playback loudness at 60 Hz to animate an orb. A global `Option+Space` hot key, registered through Carbon's `RegisterEventHotKey`, summons R2 without Accessibility permissions. The terminal client offers push-to-talk and the same commands. The app launches the core with `uv run r2 serve` and stops it on quit.

6 Implementation

6.1 Persistent prefix KV cache

Listing 1 shows the essential logic of `PrefixKVCache`. Three modes support experiments: `none`, `prefix` (RAM) and `persistent` (RAM + disk). Several prefixes—the intent prompt and the answer prompt—share an LRU of four entries.

The fingerprint hashes the model id, adapter, a hash of the chat template, the mlx-lm version and a hash of the prefix text. Because corollary 1 requires an identical prefix at identical positions, any change to any of these invalidates the file and triggers a rebuild, which is what makes persistence safe. The load is followed by `mx.eval` because MLX loads arrays lazily; without it, load times would be under-reported. The token-level check in `acquire` also guards against tokeniser merges across the prefix boundary: if the rendered prompt does not start with exactly the cached tokens, R2 falls back to a full prefill.

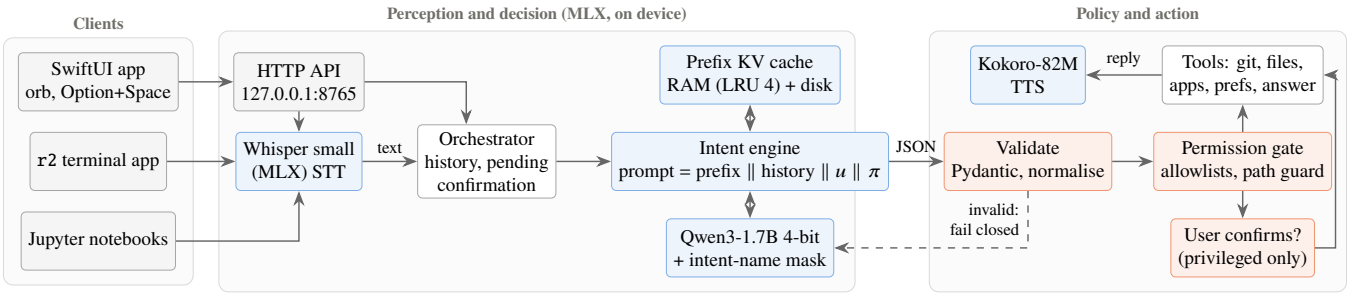


Figure 1: R2 architecture. Blue: learned models on MLX. Orange: deterministic policy that alone can authorise execution. The LLM only proposes a JSON decision; invalid proposals fall back to a safe heuristic, a clarifying question or a refusal.

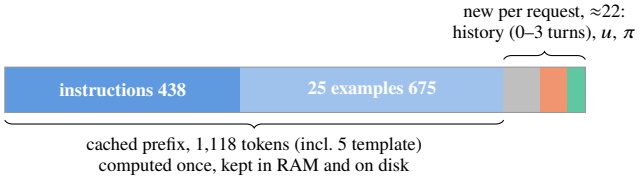


Figure 2: Token layout of one request. Only the right-hand tokens (grey: history, orange: request, green: prefill π) are processed per request; after generation the cache is trimmed back to the prefix.

6.2 Constrained decoder

Listing 2 implements the allowed set of section 4.5 as an mlx-lm logits processor. The vocabulary strings and candidate list are cached at module level, so the cost is paid once per process.

6.3 Validation, normalisation and safety

Model output passes four deterministic stages before anything executes.

1. **Parsing:** the first complete JSON object is extracted with a non-greedy decoder.
2. **Normalisation:** unknown parameter keys are dropped and search terms are mapped to globs, e.g. `swift`, `*swift*` or "swift files" → `*.swift`, while `config` → `*config*`.
3. **Validation:** a Pydantic model per intent rejects missing or extra fields and over-long values.
4. **Authorisation:** the permission gate checks the intent is implemented and enabled, apps are on the allowlist, and paths resolve inside the workspace.

Formally, a decision d executes only when

$$\mathrm{Exec}(d) \iff \mathrm{Valid}(d) \wedge \mathrm{Allowed}(d) \wedge \mathrm{InWorkspace}(d) \wedge \big(\neg \mathrm{Priv}(d) \vee \mathrm{Confirm}_{\mathrm{user}}(d)\big), \quad (14)$$

where $\mathrm{Confirm}_{\mathrm{user}}$ can only come from a later user turn, never from model text. Every failure path is closed: a parse error triggers one retry and then a heuristic classifier whose outputs are themselves validated; reading files refuses secrets (`.env*`, `*.pem`, `*.key`, `.netrc`); and `answer_question` produces text that is displayed and spoken but never executed. There is no shell tool.

Listing 1: Acquire, release and fingerprinted persistence (abridged from `models/kv_cache.py`).

```python
def fingerprint(**parts):  # model, adapter, template, mlx_lm, prefix
    h = sha256(json.dumps(parts, sort_keys=True).encode())
    return {**parts, "fingerprint": h.hexdigest()[:20]}

def acquire(self, full_tokens):
    n = len(self._prefix_tokens)
    if (self._cache is None or len(full_tokens) <= n
            or full_tokens[:n] != self._prefix_tokens):
        return None, full_tokens, 0          # miss: full prefill
    return self._cache, full_tokens[n:], n   # hit: suffix only

def release(self, cache):                    # keep only the prefix
    extra = cache[0].offset - len(self._prefix_tokens)
    if extra > 0:
        trim_prompt_cache(cache, extra)

def _try_load(self, fp):
    cache, meta = load_prompt_cache(path, return_metadata=True)
    mx.eval([c.state for c in cache])        # loads are lazy
    if meta.get("fingerprint") != fp["fingerprint"]:
        return False                         # stale: rebuild
    return cache[0].offset == len(self._prefix_tokens)
```

6.4 Software

The core is Python 3.12 (managed by `uv`) with mlx 0.32.4, mlx-lm 0.32.2, mlx-whisper 0.4.3, mlx-audio 0.6.3 and Pydantic 2.14; the client is SwiftUI (Swift 6.3, macOS 14+). 42 unit and integration tests run without model downloads, a microphone or network access.

7 Experimental Setup

Hardware and model. All measurements use an Apple M4 (4 performance and 6 efficiency CPU cores, 8-core GPU) with 16 GB of unified memory and a nominal 120 GB/s memory bandwidth, on macOS 26.5. The model is `mlx-community/Qwen3-1.7B-4bit` (table 2). Decoding is greedy (temperature 0) with at most 128 new tokens.

Datasets. The *dev set* (`eval_heldout.jsonl`, 40 cases) covers ten intents and was used while designing the prompt. The *fresh test set* (`eval_fresh.jsonl`, 24 cases, all eleven intents) was written *before* the final round of prompt changes

Listing 2: Intent-name mask (abridged from `models/constrained.py`).

```
def allowed_ids(self, prefix):
    if prefix not in self._allowed_cache:
        self._allowed_cache[prefix] = [
            tid for tid, s in self._candidates
            if any(t.startswith(prefix + s) or (prefix + s).
     startswith(t)
                   for t in self.targets)]
    return self._allowed_cache[prefix]

def __call__(self, tokens, logits):
    if self.done:
        return logits
    text = self.tokenizer.decode(tokens[self.n_prompt:].tolist
      ())
    if any(text.startswith(t) for t in self.targets):
        self.done = True                    # name complete
        return logits
    mask = np.full(logits.shape[-1], -np.inf, np.float32)
    mask[self.allowed_ids(text)] = 0.0
    return logits + mx.array(mask)
```

Table 2: Model configuration (Qwen3-1.7B, MLX 4-bit).

Layers L	28	Hidden size d	2,048
Query heads H	16	KV heads H_{kv}	8
Head dim d_h	128	FFN size	6,144
Vocabulary	151,936	Weights	4-bit, group 64
Weight file	0.94 GB	KV / token	112 KiB

and never used to tune them; we report it both before and after that round. Neither set overlaps the few-shot examples.

Metrics. *Intent accuracy* is exact match of the intent. *Parameter accuracy* additionally requires the normalised required parameters to match. *Malformed rate* counts outputs that do not parse into a valid decision; *fallback rate* counts requests answered by the heuristic. TTFT is measured from the start of generation to the first token; *decision latency* covers prompt rendering, generation, parsing and validation. For proportions we report 95% Wilson score intervals.

Benchmarks. `bench_kv.py` runs 20 dev utterances end-to-end in each cache mode. `bench_scaling.py` isolates the model: for prefix lengths n from 128 to 4,096 tokens (R2's real prompt, repeated as needed) and a 22-token suffix it times an uncached forward pass over $n + s$ tokens, a cached forward pass over s tokens, one decode step, KV size, and safetensors save/load, reporting the median of 3 runs after warm-up. `bench_voice.py` times Whisper on 8 synthetic utterances and Kokoro on 4 replies.

8 Results

8.1 End-to-end cache modes

Table 3 and fig. 3 show the effect inside the running assistant. Prefix caching cuts mean TTFT from 1,460 ms to 71 ms, a 20.5× speed-up, and whole decisions from 1.63 s to 0.23 s. The persistent mode is within 4 ms of the in-memory mode while replacing a 1.53 s rebuild with an 89 ms load at start-up (17× faster readiness). The measured speed-up is below the token-ratio bound of 51.8 (eq. (11)) because of the fixed per-pass cost and request work outside the model, quantified next.

Table 3: End-to-end cache modes, 20 requests (mean ± s.d.).

Mode	Setup	Prefilled	TTFT (ms)	Decision (ms)
None	–	1,140	1460 ± 41	1628 ± 82
Prefix (RAM)	1.53 s build	22	**71 ± 2**	227 ± 41
Persistent	89 ms load	22	75 ± 4	227 ± 42

Table 4: Model-only sweep, $s = 22$ (median of 3). KV is the allocated size; Δz is the largest absolute logit difference between cached and uncached runs.

n	Uncached (ms)	Cached (ms)	S	Decode (ms)	KV (MiB)	max $\lvert\Delta z\rvert$
128	249	56.5	4.4	14.2	28	0.47
256	433	59.0	7.3	14.1	28	0.38
512	806	60.9	13.2	14.7	56	0.31
1,024	1,583	57.0	27.8	14.0	112	0.50
1,118	**1,723**	**57.6**	**29.9**	12.4	140	0.44
1,536	2,414	62.7	38.5	16.8	168	0.44
2,048	2,664	64.7	41.2	15.3	224	0.00
3,072	4,851	71.9	67.4	16.7	336	0.28
4,096	6,220	79.8	77.9	19.9	448	0.00

8.2 Scaling with context length

Table 4 and fig. 4 isolate the model. Uncached prefill grows almost linearly, from 249 ms at 128 tokens to 6.2 s at 4,096, while the cached 22-token pass stays between 57 and 80 ms. Least-squares fits give

$$T_{\text{pre}}(N) = 65.4 + 1.365\,N + 3.51{\times}10^{-5}N^2 \text{ ms} \quad (R^2 = 0.993), \tag{15}$$

$$T_{\text{suf}}(22 \mid n) = 54.8 + 0.00556\,n \text{ ms} \quad (R^2 = 0.897). \tag{16}$$

These coefficients agree with eq. (7). Counting $P \approx 1.72$B parameters per token (1.41B in the transformer blocks plus the 0.31B tied output head), the linear coefficient implies an effective throughput $\Pi = 2P/b \approx 2.5$ TFLOP/s. At that throughput eq. (7) predicts $c = 2LHd_h/\Pi = 4.5{\times}10^{-5}$ ms/token^2, within 25% of the fitted $3.5{\times}10^{-5}$. The crossover length $N^\star = b/c \approx 39{,}000$ tokens confirms that R2 operates deep in the linear, weight-bound regime, where the speed-up approaches the token ratio minus overhead. At R2's prompt length the model-only speed-up is 29.9×; the end-to-end 20.5× of table 3 additionally includes about 14 ms of tokenisation, sampling and masking per request.

8.3 Memory, decode and disk

Figure 5a confirms eqs. (4) and (5) to the byte: every measured cache size equals $114{,}688 \cdot 256\lceil n/256 \rceil$ bytes. De-

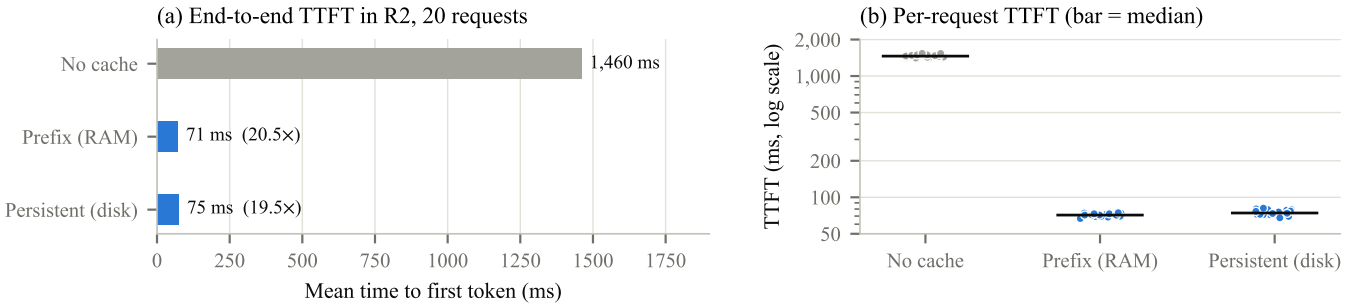


Figure 3: End-to-end TTFT inside R2 for 20 dev requests. Both cached modes reach about 71–75 ms; the spread across requests is small because only the short suffix varies.

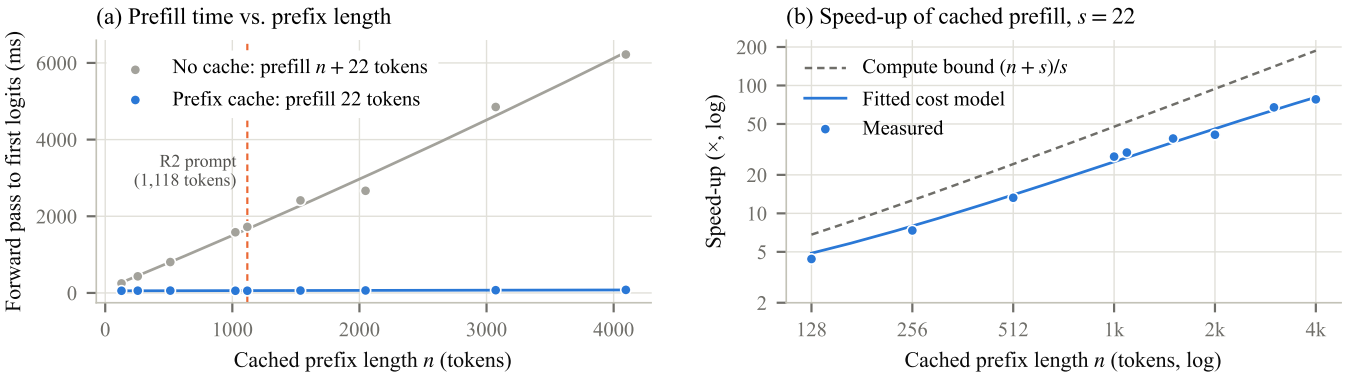


Figure 4: (a) Forward-pass time to the first logits for an uncached prompt of $n + 22$ tokens and for 22 tokens on top of an n-token cached prefix; lines are the fitted models of eqs. (7) and (8). (b) The resulting speed-up against the compute bound $(n + s)/s$; the gap is the fixed cost α of a forward pass.

coding (fig. 5b) costs $13.2 + 0.00135\,n$ ms per token. Reading the 0.94 GB of weights in 13.2 ms implies an achieved bandwidth of about 71 GB/s (59% of nominal), and at that bandwidth eq. (9) predicts a per-context-token slope of 114,688/71 GB/s = 0.0016 ms, close to the fitted 0.00135. The end-to-end generation rate is about 77 tokens/s (median), and R2's peak memory during evaluation is 1.36 GB.

Disk loading is fast when the file is in the page cache (9 ms for R2's 140 MiB at 1,118 tokens, about 16 GB/s), and 89 ms on a cold start of the assistant, which includes reading from SSD, parsing safetensors metadata and verifying the fingerprint. Both are far below the 1.5–1.7 s cost of rebuilding the prefix.

8.4 Numerical equivalence

In exact arithmetic corollary 1 guarantees identical logits. In bfloat16 the cached and uncached computations use different kernel shapes, so the largest absolute logit difference at the last position ranges from 0 to 0.5 (table 4), while the argmax token is identical at all nine lengths. End-to-end, greedy outputs with and without the cache were identical in 20 of 20 requests in both cached modes. Caching therefore changes latency, not behaviour.

Table 5: Accuracy with 95% Wilson intervals. All runs: 0% malformed, 0% fallback.

Set	n	Intent acc.	Param. acc.
Dev	40	92.5 [80.1, 97.4]	92.5 [80.1, 97.4]
Fresh, before revision	24	87.5 [69.0, 95.7]	83.3 [64.1, 93.3]
Fresh, final	24	**95.8** [79.8, 99.3]	**91.7** [74.2, 97.7]

8.5 Accuracy

Table 5 and fig. 6 report accuracy. On the fresh set R2 chooses the right intent for 23 of 24 requests and the right parameters for 22. The prompt revision that sharpened the boundaries between `general_help`, `answer_question`, `clarify_request` and `unsupported` raised fresh-set intent accuracy from 87.5% to 95.8%. Because the fresh set predates the revision, this is evidence of generalisation, although the confidence intervals are wide at these sample sizes. Median decision latency is 296 ms on the dev set (90th percentile 359 ms) and 309 ms on the fresh set (fig. 7).

8.6 Ablation: few-shot examples vs. constrained decoding

Table 6 and fig. 8 separate the two techniques. The 25 few-shot examples raise intent accuracy by 7.5 points and parameter

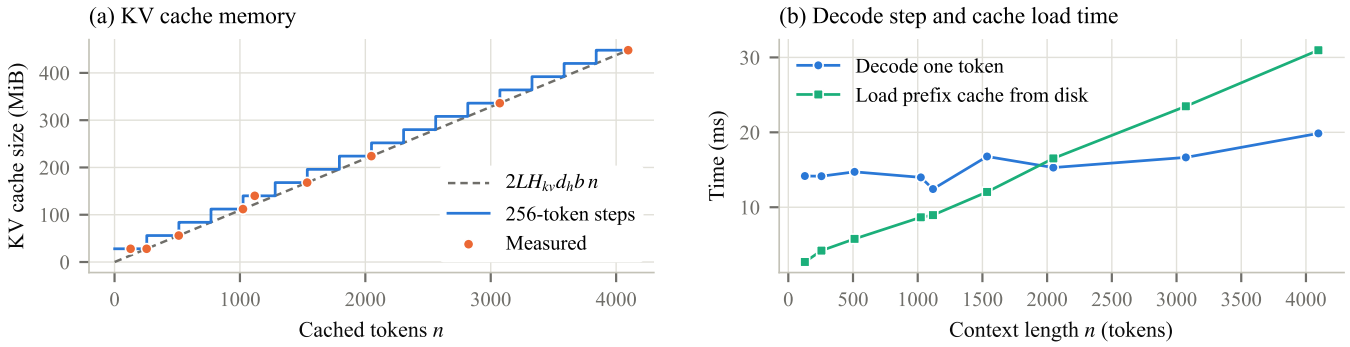


Figure 5: (a) Measured KV size (dots) matches eq. (5) exactly, including the 256-token allocation steps. (b) Decode time per token rises slowly with context; loading a prefix cache that is already in the OS page cache takes 3–31 ms.

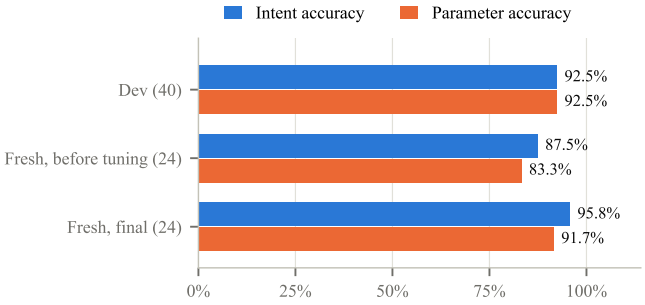


Figure 6: Intent and parameter accuracy on the dev set and on the fresh test set before and after the final prompt revision.

Table 6: Ablation on the dev set (40 cases).

Few-shot	Constrained	Intent	Params	Malformed
		85.0	77.5	2.5
	✓	85.0	77.5	2.5
✓		92.5	92.5	0.0
✓	✓	92.5	92.5	0.0

accuracy by 15 points. Constrained decoding changes nothing on this set. Its mask only governs the intent *name*, and the single malformed output without examples placed a parameter at the top level of the JSON object, outside the mask's scope. Its value is a guarantee rather than an accuracy gain: no output can name a non-existent action. The cost of the examples is prompt length (675 of 1,118 tokens), which is exactly what the prefix cache makes free: without caching, few-shot prompting would add roughly 0.9 s to every request (eq. (7)).

8.7 Error analysis

All four intent errors (figs. 9 and 10) share one pattern: vague commands such as "do the thing", "make it better", "check that" and "change that thing" are classified as `unsupported`, often with the reason "destructive actions are not allowed", instead of prompting a clarifying question. The model conflates *unclear* with *unsafe*. This failure is benign, because a refusal executes nothing, but it is the main remaining accuracy gap. The single parameter error maps "list the yaml files" to `*.yml` rather than `*.yaml`, a defensible reading that an extension-alias table would resolve. During development we also found and fixed a normalisation bug in which `*swift*` matched compiler caches under `.build/`; file search now skips build directories.

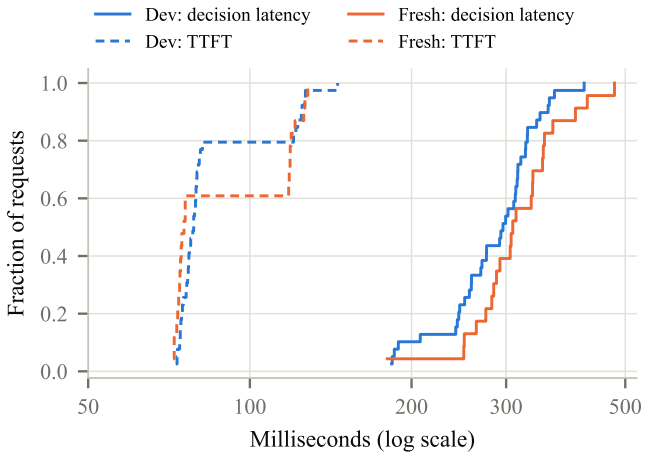


Figure 7: Cumulative distribution of TTFT and decision latency over the dev and fresh sets (the first request, which includes GPU kernel compilation, is excluded).

8.8 Voice pipeline

Whisper-small transcribed all eight synthetic utterances without word errors in a median 281 ms (real-time factor 0.17), and Kokoro-82M synthesised replies in a median 301 ms (real-time factor 0.084, fig. 11). A spoken request therefore flows through recognition (≈0.28 s), decision (≈0.30 s) and the start of synthesis (≈0.25 s for a short reply), well under a second, with every stage on device.

9 Discussion

Why narrow works. Narrowness turns the hardest parts of an LLM assistant into engineering problems with clean answers. A fixed prompt makes prefix caching exact and nearly free; a closed intent set makes constrained decoding

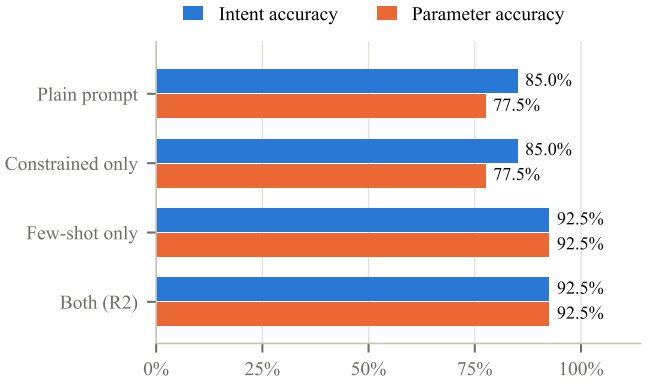


Figure 8: Ablation on the dev set. Few-shot examples account for the whole gain.

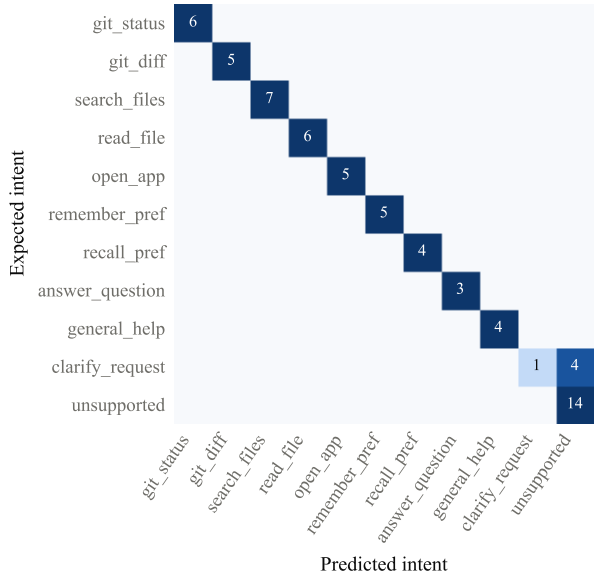


Figure 9: Confusion matrix over dev and fresh sets (64 cases). All intent errors are vague commands labelled `unsupported` instead of `clarify_request`.

trivial and sound; and typed decisions make authorisation a deterministic policy rather than a property of model text. The resulting assistant is fast because it reads the long part of its prompt once, and safe because the model has no path to execution that the policy does not see.

Caching makes few-shot prompting affordable. The ablation and the cost model connect: few-shot examples provide the accuracy, and the prefix cache removes their latency cost. Without the cache, each example token costs about 1.4 ms on every request; with it, examples are paid for once at start-up (or never, with a warm disk cache). This suggests a general design rule for on-device assistants: put as much of the specification as possible into a stable prefix, and keep the variable part short.

Limits of the design.

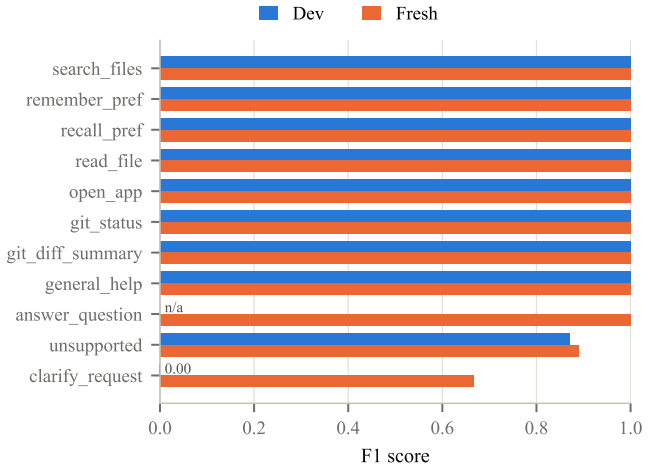


Figure 10: Per-intent F1. `answer_question` does not occur in the dev set.

- **Small evaluation sets.** With 40 and 24 cases, one case moves accuracy by 2.5–4.2 points, and the intervals in table 5 overlap.
- **Single machine, synthetic speech.** Timings come from one M4. The speech test uses synthesised rather than recorded, accented or noisy speech.
- **Free-form answers.** `answer_question` replies from a 1.7B model are short and sometimes imprecise. They are labelled as answers and never executed.
- **Prefix only.** The cache reuses the system prefix but not the conversation history. Multi-turn reuse would require radix-style matching [8].
- **Stale cache files.** Old cache files from earlier prompt versions remain on disk until removed. An on-disk LRU would bound this.

Threats to validity. The dev set influenced prompt design, so its accuracy is optimistic; the fresh set mitigates but does not remove this, since the final revision was guided by general failure categories observed on the dev set. Benchmarks ran on a machine with other applications open; we report medians and show per-request spread, and a run-time watchdog aborted runs if free memory dropped below 25%.

Ethics and privacy. All audio, text and preferences stay on the device; no account or network service is required after the one-time model download. Preferences are stored only after explicit confirmation, and the assistant cannot read common secret files.

10 Future Work

1. **Conversation-level reuse:** match the longest cached prefix including history, with a token-level radix tree [8].
2. **KV quantisation:** measure 8- and 4-bit caches [16, 17], expected to matter only for longer contexts.

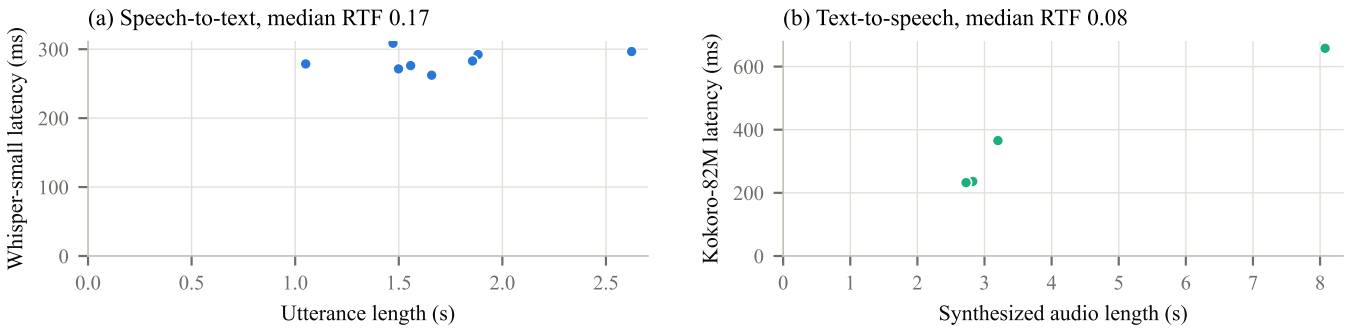


Figure 11: On-device speech latency. (a) Whisper-small transcribes 1–2.6 s utterances in about 0.28 s. (b) Kokoro-82M synthesises speech about 12× faster than real time.

3. **Parameter grammars:** extend the mask from intent names to full per-intent JSON schemas with an FSM or pushdown engine [18, 20].
4. **Clarification:** a contrastive set of vague vs. destructive requests and LoRA fine-tuning [34] on a larger synthetic dataset.
5. **Decode speed:** speculative decoding [35] for longer spoken answers.
6. **Larger studies:** more requests, recorded speech, several Apple chips and other small models.

11 Conclusion

R2 shows that a small local model can feel like a native voice assistant when the system around it is designed for a narrow task. A persistent prefix KV cache turns a 1.5 s prompt into a 71 ms response start with identical outputs. Its behaviour follows from a few lines of theory: prefix invariance, the KV memory formula and a linear-plus-quadratic cost model. Few-shot examples deliver 95.8% intent accuracy on unseen requests, and a fail-closed policy keeps every action under the user's control.

Reproducibility

All numbers in this paper are produced by scripts in the repository and stored in `artifacts/`:

```
uv sync && uv run pytest                    # 42 tests
uv run python training/bench_kv.py          # Table 3, Fig. 3
uv run python training/bench_scaling.py     # Table 4, Figs.
    4-5
uv run python training/evaluate.py --backend mlx [--eval data/
    eval_fresh.jsonl]
uv run python training/evaluate.py --backend mlx --no-few-shot
    --no-constrain
uv run python training/bench_voice.py       # Fig. 11
uv run python paper/make_figures.py         # all figures
```

Author Contributions

Siavash Shokrtalab (full-stack engineering): system architecture, Python core and HTTP API, SwiftUI macOS client, voice pipeline integration, tooling and testing. **Alireza Panahdoost** (research and machine learning): research questions, KV cache and constrained-decoding methodology, theoretical analysis, benchmark and evaluation design, error analysis. Both authors wrote and approved the manuscript.

Acknowledgements

We thank the developers of MLX, mlx-lm, Qwen3, Whisper and Kokoro for releasing their work openly. Parts of the implementation and of this manuscript were prepared with the help of an AI coding assistant; the authors are responsible for all content.

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A System Prompt Excerpt

```
You are R2, a narrow, local macOS developer assistant (like Siri, but only for developer tasks in the
user's active workspace).

Turn the user's request into exactly ONE JSON object and nothing else:
{"intent": "<intent>", "parameters": {...}}

Intents (parameters) - when to use:
- general_help {} - ONLY when the user asks about R2 itself: what you can do / how to use you
- git_status {} - branch, repo status, uncommitted or changed files
- git_diff_summary {} - summary or size of the diff / what changed in the code
- search_files {"pattern": "<glob, e.g. *.py, *test*, README*>"} - find, list or locate files by name or type
- read_file {"path": "<relative file path>"} - show, read, print or display the contents of a specific file
- open_app {"app_name": "<one of the approved apps>"} - launch or open an application
- remember_preference {"key": "<snake_case key>", "value": "<value>"} - user tells you a personal preference ...
- recall_preference {"key": "<snake_case key>"} - user asks about their OWN previously saved preference ...
- answer_question {"question": "<the user's question>"} - a software-development knowledge question ...
- clarify_request {"question": "<short follow-up question>"} - a vague command whose target is unclear ...
- unsupported {"reason": "<short reason>"} - chit-chat, trivia, math, destructive or out-of-scope requests
... approved apps, rules, and 25 worked examples (675 tokens) follow.
```

B Local HTTP API

Method	Path	Purpose
GET	`/health`, `/status`, `/voices`	liveness; model and KV cache state; voice list
POST	`/ask` {`text`}	text request → reply, speech, intent, metrics
POST	`/confirm`, `/cancel`, `/reset`	answer a pending confirmation; clear history
POST	`/ask_audio` (WAV, ≤16 MB)	Whisper transcription, then `/ask`
POST	`/tts` {`text`, `voice`, `speed`}	Kokoro speech as WAV

C Evaluation Set Composition

Intent	Dev	Fresh	Intent	Dev	Fresh
`git_status`	4	2	`recall_preference`	2	2
`git_diff_summary`	3	2	`answer_question`	0	3
`search_files`	5	2	`general_help`	3	1
`read_file`	4	2	`clarify_request`	3	2
`open_app`	3	2	`unsupported`	10	4
`remember_preference`	3	2	**Total**	**40**	**24**